14 November 2025

Committee Secretary
Joint Standing Committee on Electoral Matters
PO Box 6021
Parliament House
CANBERRA ACT 2600

Dear Committee Secretary,

Thank you for inviting The Nationals to provide a submission to the Joint Standing Committee on Electoral Matters' inquiry into the conduct of the 2025 federal election.

Implementation of Electoral Reform

The Nationals recognise the Australian Electoral Commission's constructive and proactive communication regarding changes to the Commonwealth Electoral Act. These important reforms will necessitate significant systemic adjustments for the regulatory authority, political parties, and other stakeholders. We encourage the Government to seriously consider whether January 1 2027, is a better date for the commencement of the changes and would offer our support for the later start date.

Given the size and scale of the changes, we encourage the Committee to allow these changes to be bedded down and working before considering any further significant reform to the funding and disclosure regime. We would not support relitigating the changes agreed in the last term.

We understand that another party has suggested establishing a standing working group involving representatives from all major political parties and the AEC to ensure a common understanding of electoral matters. We would support and be willing participants in such a group and note that similar arrangements already exist in other areas.

Australian Electoral Commission management of the 2025 federal election

The AEC planned, managed and delivered the 2025 election campaign competently and in line with community expectations. As in every election, there were isolated incidents that required rectification, but in each case where The Nationals raised an issue, it was treated promptly and professionally by the senior staff at the Commission.

An issue that was raised by the Nationals – Victoria and the Member for Mallee, was the location of the ballot draw taking place outside of the electorate. We would ask that future consideration be given to conduct ballot draws within the electorate, especially large regional electorates.

Prepoll

The Nationals would support the reduction of prepoll from two weeks back to one week. We no longer have an election day, but rather an election period. The large number of prepoll locations and the extended hours that they are open for make it very difficult for volunteers to support their candidates over an extended period of time. There is no doubt that the participation of volunteers on prepoll locations is of significant benefit to the smooth running of elections.

We understand the huge task that the AEC undertakes to identify and lease prepoll locations. We respectfully note that identifying sites with access to toilets and shade, or at the very least reasonably close access to toilets and the ability to erect appropriate tents or marquees, should be demonstrated to be a high priority in site selection.

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THE NATIONALS for Regional Australia

Behaviour at polling places

We are concerned that the public commentary around alleged behaviour at polling places has devolved into faith-based discrimination and vilification rather than an assessment of what happened. While Labor's recent concern about behaviour in polling places is welcome, after years of abuse of Nationals candidates, volunteers and supporters being ignored, Labor has degenerated to labelling people of faith as a cult. A person's faith should not be a measure of their suitability to participate in our democracy. All Australians should be free to participate freely in our democratic process.

We all agree that there are standards of behaviour that must be adhered to. That does not give the government the right to try to "cancel" people of faith who do not share their political views and who advocate a vote against them.

Yours sincerely

[redacted]

Lincoln Folo
Federal Director

THE NATIONALS for Regional Australia